



"A recognisable voice gives you longevity"

SPOTIFY INDIA'S **DHRUVANK VAIDYA** ON WHAT THE PLATFORM ACTUALLY SEES, WHERE THE MONEY IS STUCK, AND WHICH NUMBERS A CREATOR SHOULD WATCH

By **Jayesh Shinde** | editor@digit.in

Dhruvank Vaidya isn't like any other podcaster featured in this cover story. As Head of Music and Podcasts at Spotify India, Vaidya is the one person looking at the whole market – which makes his answers useful in a different way, and worth reading with one eye open, since a platform's account of the medium is also a case for the platform. But the questions podcasters keep asking – is anyone listening all the way through, why won't advertisers spend, what should I optimise for – are ones only someone holding the aggregate data can answer. His short version: India has moved past experimentation but not maturity, and the money is waiting on infra, not on audience.

How large is India's podcast audience today?

Dhruvank: India's podcast landscape is moving beyond experimentation, with creator-led, personality-driven shows

increasingly becoming a mainstream part of how audiences consume spoken-word content. Spotify Wrapped 2025 reflects the breadth of that audience: Figuring Out with Raj Shamani took the top spot, followed by The Horror Show by Khooni Monday, The Desi Crime Podcast and The Ranveer Show हिंदी. The range of formats and voices – spanning comedy, true crime, business, entertainment and regional-language content – points to a category with increasingly diverse and established audiences. I would describe India as a market that has moved beyond experimentation, but hasn't yet reached maturity. That's where the opportunity lies.

How quickly is podcast consumption growing in India?

Dhruvank: The growth story is less about a short-term spike and more about podcasts becoming part of people's everyday habits. Podcasts fit naturally into moments where other forms of media cannot – during a commute, while

exercising, travelling, doing household chores or simply taking a break from screens. There are three things driving this growth. First, access: affordable data and near-universal smartphone access have removed much of the friction that once made podcasts feel like a niche, urban habit. Second, content has matured: the ecosystem is diverse, spanning genres, creators, and languages. Podcasting in India today doesn't look like it did five years ago. It increasingly looks like premium, personality-driven content that competes for attention alongside everything else on a phone screen. The other important shift is discovery. On Spotify, 97% of Indian users say they rely on the platform to discover new podcast hosts, while 98% say Spotify understands them. That speaks to the role a platform can play in helping emerging creators get discovered – through behaviour-driven recommendations, language-aware discovery and an understanding of how Indians actually consume content.